

AN ACT

relating to the accreditation of certain postsecondary educational institutions in this state or of certain programs offered by those institutions.

BE IT ENACTED BY THE LEGISLATURE OF THE STATE OF TEXAS:

SECTION 1. Section 61.003(13), Education Code, is amended to read as follows:

(13) "Recognized accrediting agency" means ~~[the Southern Association of Colleges and Schools and]~~ any ~~[other]~~ association or organization so designated by the board.

SECTION 2. Section 61.051(a), Education Code, is amended to read as follows:

(a) The board represents the highest authority in the state in matters of public higher education and is charged with the duty to take an active part in promoting quality education throughout the state by:

(1) providing a statewide perspective to ensure the efficient and effective use of higher education resources and to eliminate unnecessary duplication;

(2) developing and evaluating progress toward a long-range master plan for higher education and providing analysis and recommendations to link state spending for higher education with the goals of the long-range master plan;

(3) collecting and making accessible data on higher

1 education in the state and aggregating and analyzing that data to
2 support policy recommendations;

3 (4) making recommendations to improve the efficiency
4 and effectiveness of transitions, including between high school and
5 postsecondary education, between institutions of higher education
6 for transfer purposes, and between postsecondary education and the
7 workforce; ~~and~~

8 (5) administering programs and trusteed funds for
9 financial aid and other grants as necessary to achieve the state's
10 long-range goals and as directed by the legislature; and

11 (6) adopting rules or taking other action necessary to
12 ensure that each institution of higher education is properly
13 accredited as required to participate in the federal financial aid
14 program under 20 U.S.C. Section 1070a and other federal student
15 financial assistance programs.

16 SECTION 3. Section 61.0515(a), Education Code, is amended
17 to read as follows:

18 (a) To earn a baccalaureate degree, a student may not be
19 required by a general academic teaching institution to complete
20 more than the minimum number of semester credit hours required for
21 the degree by the institution's recognized accrediting agency
22 ~~[Southern Association of Colleges and Schools or its successor]~~
23 unless the institution determines that there is a compelling
24 academic reason for requiring completion of additional semester
25 credit hours for the degree.

26 SECTION 4. Section 61.05151(a), Education Code, is amended
27 to read as follows:

(a) To earn an associate degree, a student may not be required by an institution of higher education to complete more than the minimum number of semester credit hours required for the degree by the institution's recognized accrediting agency [~~Southern Association of Colleges and Schools or its successor~~] unless the institution determines that there is a compelling academic reason for requiring completion of additional semester credit hours for the degree.

SECTION 5. Section 61.8235(f), Education Code, is amended to read as follows:

(f) A student enrolled in a board-established program of study who transfers from a public junior college, public state college, or public technical institute to another public junior college, public state college, or public technical institute that offers a similar program, regardless of whether the institution has adopted the board-established program of study, shall receive academic credit from the institution to which the student transferred for each of the courses that the student has successfully completed in the program of study curriculum. Unless otherwise required by the institution's recognized accrediting agency [~~Commission on Colleges of the Southern Association of Colleges and Schools~~], the student may complete the program of study at the institution to which the student transferred by completing only the remaining number of semester credit hours the student would need to complete the program of study at the institution from which the student transferred.

SECTION 6. Section 107.151(c), Education Code, is amended

to read as follows:

(c) Notwithstanding any other provision of this subchapter, the university may operate as a general academic teaching institution only after the Texas Higher Education Coordinating Board certifies that the university is accredited by a recognized accrediting agency, as defined by Section 61.003, [~~the Southern Association of Colleges and Schools Commission on Colleges~~] and has been approved by the coordinating board to offer one or more degree programs. Until the coordinating board certifies that the conditions of this subsection have been met, the board of regents may operate a branch campus of Texas Woman's University in the city of Dallas.

SECTION 7. Section 107.201(c), Education Code, is amended to read as follows:

(c) Notwithstanding any other provision of this subchapter, the university may operate as a general academic teaching institution only after the Texas Higher Education Coordinating Board certifies that the university is accredited by a recognized accrediting agency, as defined by Section 61.003, [~~the Southern Association of Colleges and Schools Commission on Colleges~~] and has been approved by the coordinating board to offer one or more degree programs. Until the coordinating board certifies that the conditions of this subsection have been met, the board of regents may operate a branch campus of Texas Woman's University in the city of Houston.

SECTION 8. Section 130.301, Education Code, is amended by adding Subdivision (3) to read as follows:

1 (3) "Recognized accrediting agency" has the meaning
2 assigned by Section 61.003.

3 SECTION 9. Section 130.305, Education Code, is amended to
4 read as follows:

5 Sec. 130.305. ACCREDITATION. A public junior college
6 offering a baccalaureate degree program under this subchapter must
7 meet all applicable accreditation requirements of a recognized
8 accrediting agency [~~the Commission on Colleges of the Southern~~
9 ~~Association of Colleges and Schools~~].

10 SECTION 10. Section 130.307(c), Education Code, is amended
11 to read as follows:

12 (c) Before a public junior college may be authorized to
13 offer a baccalaureate degree program under this subchapter, the
14 public junior college must submit a report to the coordinating
15 board that includes:

16 (1) a long-term financial plan for receiving
17 accreditation from a recognized accrediting agency [~~the Commission~~
18 ~~on Colleges of the Southern Association of Colleges and Schools~~];

19 (2) a long-term plan for faculty recruitment that:

20 (A) indicates the ability to pay the increased
21 salaries of doctoral faculty;

22 (B) identifies recruitment strategies for new
23 faculty; and

24 (C) ensures the program would not draw faculty
25 employed by a neighboring institution offering a similar program;

26 (3) detailed information on the manner of program and
27 course delivery; and

1 (4) detailed information regarding existing
2 articulation agreements and dual enrollment agreements indicating:

3 (A) that at least three articulation agreements
4 have been established with general academic teaching institutions
5 or medical and dental units, or the reasons why no articulation
6 agreements have been established; and

7 (B) that, with the agreement of the applicable
8 general academic teaching institution or medical and dental unit,
9 established articulation agreements are at capacity.

10 SECTION 11. This Act takes effect September 1, 2025.

President of the Senate

Speaker of the House

I hereby certify that S.B. No. 530 passed the Senate on April 22, 2025, by the following vote: Yeas 24, Nays 7; and that the Senate concurred in House amendment on May 7, 2025, by the following vote: Yeas 23, Nays 8.

Secretary of the Senate

I hereby certify that S.B. No. 530 passed the House, with amendment, on May 1, 2025, by the following vote: Yeas 114, Nays 28, one present not voting.

Chief Clerk of the House

Approved:

Date

Governor